

A budget helps you identify what I call “money leaks.” Those are all the little holes and cracks in your spending habits that let your money leak out of your wallet—without you even realizing what’s going on. You know what I’m talking about. How many times have you gotten to the end of the month without a dime to your name and with no idea where your whole paycheck went? A few extra groceries here, a couple of restaurant meals there, a few stops at Starbucks every week, and then *BOOM*. You’re broke. I’ve seen this happen with high-income, two-income couples, and I’ve seen it happen with minimum-wage single parents. Even though this looks and feels like a *money* problem, most of the time it’s not. Instead, it’s a *behavior* problem—one you have the power to change. No matter what kind of income you have, if you stay disciplined and make a plan for where your money is going, you’ll find your pockets full long after payday.